The War of the Worlds: Themes

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Themes

In your exam, you will use your knowledge of the whole novel to explore the key themes, characters and ideas in the text.

Understanding the central themes of this celebrated science-fiction novel and how they are shaped by the context in which H.G. Wells was writing will help you confidently write your answer to the exam question.

Here are some of the central themes of the novel:

- **Nature and evolution**
- **Fear and the unknown**
- **War and destruction**

Nature and evolution

Nature and evolution

In The War of the Worlds, H.G. Wells explores the theme of nature and evolution. The Martians, or "Invaders", are presented as superior to humans in **evolutionary** terms and in their advanced use of technology. However, ultimately they are defeated by nature: simple earthly bacteria.

Knowledge and evidence:

- Wells depicts some evolutionary similarities between humans and Martians:
  - The narrator comments that Martians "may be descended from beings not unlike" humans and in Book Two, Wells writes, "A Martian came across the fields about midday, laying the stuff with a jet of superheated steam…", which reminds the reader of human movement

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

    - Wells writes how the Martians were "slain by the **putrefactive** and disease bacteria against which their systems were unprepared"

- Wells' key point is that evolutionary strength does not just occur by chance and it is largely linked to environmental factors:
    - At the time of publication, Darwin's theory of evolution and natural selection was not widely accepted, although it had been in existence for nearly half a century and Wells was fascinated by it
    - This theory – that the individuals who are most suited to their environment are most likely to survive and pass on their characteristics to the next generation – is important in the novel

- In the narrative, it is clear that people suffer under the Martians' rule:
    - The artilleryman is "grim set on living" and he is representative of S**sSocial Darwinism** in the book – the "survival of the fittest"

- However, humans have, for a very long time, been "ruthless [with] utter destruction" towards animals and anyone else:
    - In Chapter Nine in Book One, one character questions "Why not shell the darned things [the Martians] strite off and finish 'em?"

- Wells reinforces the idea that survival is not just physical; it is linked to mental and emotional strength and humans have to adapt to the imminent threat of the Martians to survive
- Humans have developed resistance to different challenges and threats:
    - In the Epilogue, Wells reminds the reader that the Martians had "...an entire ignorance of the putrefactive process…", underlining the humans' advantage over the alien life forms

What is Wells' intention?

- One of Wells' key ideas is that evolution is not just physical – it can be affected by mental strength and determination
- There are **myriad** factors that affect how people react in different situations
- Wells presents Darwin's theory of evolution as being key to the story but also suggests that readers should consider the role that humans have in the world:
    - In Book One, the narrator's neighbour has an alternative view of the Martians: "It's a pity they make themselves so unapproachable. It would be curious to know how they live… we might learn a thing or two"
    - Wells reminds readers that we can adapt by learning from others

Help me understand

Fear and the unknown

discomfort and fear for both characters and readers.

The novel fits into a category known as invasion literature (made famous in Colonel George Chesney's novella, The Battle of Dorking, written in 1871). The Martians are representative of the **xenophobic** feelings that were dominant in society in the latter part of the 19th century.

Knowledge and evidence:

- The narrator is very fearful of the Martians in the story and his own familiar surroundings offer little comfort:
  - The well-known becomes alien to him, perhaps because he sees his world through the eyes of outsiders, and comments "We can't possibly stay here"
  - His fear of the unknown is demonstrated by his contradictory "flight or fight" feelings, as he plans to escape to "Leatherhead" but also reassures his wife, "Stop here… you are safe here"

- The character of the curate is also fearful as he struggles to understand how alien life forms are present, having led a life controlled by religious thought:
  - He asks, in Book One, Chapter Thirteen, "What sins have we done… What are these Martians?"
  - His references to **Sodom and Gomorrah** show how the Curate turns to his religious beliefs when faced with a strange, unfamiliar new life
  - When he states "This must be the beginning of the end… the end!" his spontaneous expression of fear reminds readers of the **apocalyptical** themes of the novel

- People in Wells' society felt under-prepared for change and there was a sense of unease regarding a possible foreign invasion:
  - The arrival of the Martians is representative of this underlying fear as the curate asks, "What are we to do? Has the earth been given over to them?"
  - In response to strange and other-worldly events, people react in a variety of ways, some of which may be uncharacteristic

What is Wells' intention?

- Wells uses religion as a means of representing people's fear of the unknown:
  - People at the time would have been suspicious of anything challenging their religious beliefs

- Wells reinforces the Martians' "otherness" by incorporating characteristics that humans would be fearful of:
  - He reflects a fundamental societal fear of change and outsiders

War and destruction

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War and destruction

In the story, as its title reminds us, there is a battle between the Martians and humans, with the "Invaders" setting out to **annihilate** humanity. In the late 1800s, when War of the Worlds was published, Britain was a colonial nation and many people would have lived through different conflicts.

As a social commentator, H.G. Wells was critical of British **imperialism** and his novel clearly focuses on the negative impact of war and how its destructiveness can affect people both physically and psychologically. Through his characters, he also focuses on how a lack of self-awareness and being **reactionary** can be damaging, resulting in internal battles and being closed off to new ways of thinking.

Knowledge and evidence:

- The narrator struggles at times to describe the horrors he witnesses:
  - In Chapter Ten, Book One, Wells writes, "And the Thing I saw! How can I describe it?"
  - Later he observes a "monstrous tripod… striding… smashing…" with the alliteration and sibilance adding to the fear a reader experiences (and contributing to our concerns about the outcome of the war)

- The negative impact of war is also demonstrated through the character of the artilleryman, who transitions from a hard-working soldier to a dreamer who has lost touch with reality
- As the narrative progresses, Wells presents in-fighting and conflict between characters as they struggle to survive, such as when the narrator attacks the curate
- The idea of war is also presented through the conflicting themes of strength/courage and cowardice/fear:
  - Wells presents the impact of war through these mixed emotions when the narrator encounters a dead body but soon afterwards, has to "[push]... on up the hill"
  - In a challenging situation such as this, he has no choice but to triumph over fear and adversity and move on

- In his **dystopian** war, Wells uses fictional weaponry, such as the "HeatRay", "Black Smoke" and "Tripods" to predict what might happen in the real world future in terms of the brutality of warfare:
  - In Chapter Five, Book One, the HeatRay is introduced and the narrator comments how men "...were suddenly and momentarily turned to fire"
  - The matter-of-fact tone used to describe this horrifying and otherworldly act shows how something unfamiliar can quickly become an accepted part of life

- Wells presents how insignificant the humans seem in the face of the Martians' power, describing them as " a little knot of small vertical black shapes" surrounded by "green smoke"
- Humans group together in different places, seeking safety in numbers, reflecting their vulnerability

- However, despite the Martians' **martial** dominance, they are eventually obliterated due to not having the same immunity to bacteria that humans have

What is Wells' intention?

- Through the various events in the story, Wells depicts the fragility of life
- He uses the war with the Martians to represent how life can be a battle between good and evil
- The war with the Martians acts as a great social leveller – everyone is equal in conflict:
  - Wells shows how people from different social classes would not usually have mixed in the 19th century

- Ultimately, Wells' novel is perhaps a lesson in how to re-build a society and how we can face adversity and respond to unexpected or terrifying situations

Sources

H. G. Wells | Making Britain. (n.d.). https://www5.open.ac.uk/research-projects/making-britain/content/h-g-wells

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